

The Debate Over the Constitution

Map how Federalists, Anti-Federalists, small-state delegates, and supporters of a Bill of Rights argued over whether to ratify the new U.S. Constitution.

? Historical challenge

In 1787–1788, Americans fiercely debated whether to ratify the new U.S. Constitution. Supporters said the country needed a stronger national government; opponents feared it would trample state and individual rights. Investigate the arguments, then map how four different groups saw the same question.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

The Constitution of the United States – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The document itself; Article VII set the nine-state ratification requirement.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the Constitution require to take effect?
- Which parts might different groups worry about?

SOURCES 2

Federalist Papers: Primary Documents in American History – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 85 essays written by Hamilton, Madison, and Jay to urge ratification.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Who wrote the Federalist Papers, and why?
- What point of view do they argue?

SOURCES 3

The Ratification Debate on the Constitution – Bill of Rights Institute

SECONDARY SOURCE

How Anti-Federalist demands for a Bill of Rights shaped ratification.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did Anti-Federalists oppose the Constitution as written?
- How was the disagreement resolved?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.



Federalists (Hamilton, Madison, Jay, Washington)

S1

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?



Anti-Federalists (Henry, Mason, S. Adams, R.H. Lee)

S2

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

THE EVENT

Ratifying the U.S. Constitution

1787–1788

Philadelphia and the state ratifying conventions



Supporters of a Bill of Rights (swing delegates)

S3

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?



Small-state delegates (New Jersey, Delaware)

S4

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Compare the voices

Where did perspectives overlap?

Where did they conflict?

Whose perspective is missing from the sources?

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- With a partner, compare your cards. Where did you record the same thing? Where did your evidence differ?
- Which group's perspective was hardest to find in the sources? Why might that be?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was ratifying the Constitution the right choice for the new nation? Support your answer with evidence from at least two sources and at least two groups' perspectives.